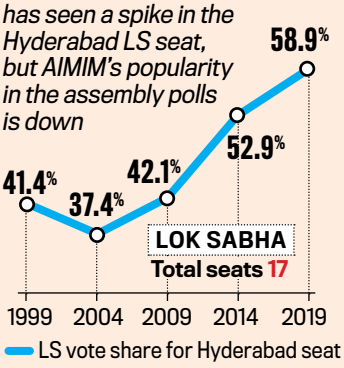
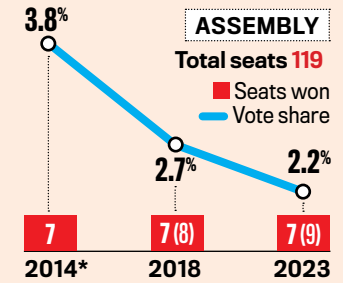
FORTIFIED BASTION

Owaisi's vote share has seen a spike in the Hyderabad LS seat, but AIMIM's popularity in the assembly polls is down





AIMIM has won the same 7 seats in the past three assembly polls in Telangana

*2014 vote share extrapolated from undivided AP poll data, contested seats in ( )

fortunes appear to be on a decline. Another is Muslim disaffection; they are staunch supporters, but there is a feeling that the AIMIM is not delivering on all its promises. Then, there's the perception issue. The Karnataka assembly election last year was the fifth in a row in which the AIMIM drew a blank (it had contested two seats). That said, party candidates have won local polls in several states—they even had five MLAs in Bihar, though four decamped later.

The AIMIM is an intriguing political experiment, borne aloft and encumbered by its USP. Though anchored in Muslim identity, it has yet to gain wide acceptance and political legitimacy as the 'party of the Indian Muslim'. The fragmented distribution of the community, which forms 14 per cent of India's population (2011 Census), also makes a pan-Indian Muslim party unviable in the context of a Lok Sabha election.

Yet, there is no other leader who has so consistently raised issues and concerns of the Muslim minority. It's also the only party (except for the Muslim League or IUML) that gives space to the rising political aspirations of the Muslim youth. Back home in Hyderabad, the perception about the party goes down to brass tacks, assessing what the MLAs and those in local bodies, including the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation, have done for the community. The verdict: they have not done enough, especially to develop infrastructure in the Old City areas. "The rise in the number of single mothers, increasing cases of substance and alcohol abuse, livelihood worries, all this is making the Muslim poor drift away from electoral politics," says lawyer and social activist Afsar Jahan.

At the national level, there is no denying the "nuisance value" of the AIMIM for fellow anti-saffron formations, especially in areas with a high Muslim concentration. In the 2022 Uttar Pradesh assembly election, the Samajwadi Party lost at least seven seats in close contests when the AIMIM candidates polled more votes than the losing margin. This has led to Opposition parties referring to the AIMIM as the "BJP's B team", and is perhaps also the reason Owaisi has been kept out of the INDIA bloc.

Owaisi's strength is being vocal on issues concerning the "rights of minorities". He says the BJP has only hatred for the minorities, and points to how the party even refuses to mention the word "minorities" in its manifesto. "Just check the BJP's advertisement on April 17 in various newspapers. When they talk about government loans or aid to start a business, it alludes to SC/STs and OBCs. The BJP refuses to even mention the word minorities, forget Muslims," says an indignant Owaisi.

But it's still no excuse for why his own legislators face charges of inaction. Hyderabad has stayed true to Owaisi all these years, but if the murmurs get louder, the AIMIM chief will have reason to worry. ■

AAM AADMI PARTY

Falling Back on Ram

The party takes recourse to the Lord, promising governance inspired by Ram Rajya ideals

By Avishek G. Dastidar

It's not new from the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), led by 'Ram bhakt' Arvind Kejriwal, but worth noting because god is in the details. It was Ram Navami on April 17. And a perfect occasion for the embattled party, whose supremo has been in judicial custody since March 21, to launch its own vision of Ram Rajya as part of its poll campaign, with a website titled 'AAP ka RamRajya'. Its logo: an image of Kejriwal waving the national flag alongside a sketch of Lord Ram.

The website mostly has YouTube clips of some of Kejriwal's past speeches and interactions with the party's legislators in Punjab, Goa and Gujarat in which they discuss welfare work. It also has video clips of several of the AAP government's flagship schemes like mohalla clinics, free bus tickets to women etc. But the heart of the message is that the party would model its governance on the principles of Ram Rajya—a metaphor for the mythical, utopian rule of the Hindu deity in Ayodhya based on justice, equality and welfare. "The rule of Lord Ram in Ayodhya is considered an ideal model of governance in the world. We are inspired to

RIGHT TURN? AAP leaders Saurabh Bharadwaj, Sanjay Singh and Atishi launch the 'AAP ka RamRajya' website in Delhi, Apr. 17



ARUN KUMAR